

Countable Additivity is Not First-Order:

A Companion Note to “Probability from Observation”

Patrick S. Mahon

Abstract

Proposition 3.9 of the companion paper shows that collective exhaustion (CE) is not derivable from any first-order structural condition on a query system. We show here that this obstruction is not specific to query systems. In the first-order language of Boolean algebras equipped with a normalized finitely additive charge, no first-order theory characterizes those models whose charge extends to a σ -additive measure on the generated σ -algebra. Equivalently, countable additivity is not first-order axiomatizable in this language. The proof uses the same ultraproduct mechanism as Proposition 3.9, now stated in full generality.

1 The language

Let $\mathcal{L}_{\text{BA},\mu}$ be the one-sorted first-order language with:

- Boolean operations $\wedge, \vee, \neg, 0, 1$;
- for each rational $q \in [0, 1] \cap \mathbb{Q}$, unary relation symbols $M_{\leq q}(x)$ and $M_{\geq q}(x)$, intended to mean $\mu(x) \leq q$ and $\mu(x) \geq q$ respectively.

A structure for $\mathcal{L}_{\text{BA},\mu}$ is a Boolean algebra B together with a $[0, 1]$ -valued finitely additive probability μ , encoded through the truth of the predicates $M_{\leq q}$ and $M_{\geq q}$. Using rational comparison predicates rather than a function symbol into $[0, 1]$ avoids introducing a second numeric sort.

Definition 1.1 (First-order theory of finitely additive probabilities). Let T_{fa} be the $\mathcal{L}_{\text{BA},\mu}$ -theory axiomatizing:

- (i) B is a Boolean algebra;
- (ii) normalization: $\mu(0) = 0$ and $\mu(1) = 1$;
- (iii) monotonicity: $x \leq y \Rightarrow \mu(x) \leq \mu(y)$;
- (iv) finite additivity: for all rationals r, s with $r + s \leq 1$,

$$x \wedge y = 0 \wedge M_{\leq r}(x) \wedge M_{\leq s}(y) \Rightarrow M_{\leq r+s}(x \vee y),$$

and similarly for lower bounds.

The class of Boolean algebras with normalized finitely additive probability is first-order axiomatizable in $\mathcal{L}_{\text{BA},\mu}$. Countable additivity, by contrast, requires quantification over an arbitrary countable sequence $(a_n)_{n \in \mathbb{N}}$ — not available in first-order logic — and so is not a sentence of $\mathcal{L}_{\text{BA},\mu}$.

2 The metatheorem

Proposition 2.1 (Countable additivity is not first-order). *There is no first-order $\mathcal{L}_{\text{BA},\mu}$ -theory $T \supseteq T_{\text{fa}}$ such that, for every $(B, \mu) \models T_{\text{fa}}$,*

$$(B, \mu) \models T \iff \mu \text{ extends to a } \sigma\text{-additive measure on } \sigma(B).$$

Equivalently, countable additivity is not first-order axiomatizable among finitely additive probability Boolean algebras.

Proof. Let E be the Boolean algebra of finite-cofinite subsets of $\mathbb{Q}$, fix an enumeration $q : \mathbb{N} \rightarrow \mathbb{Q}$, and let δ_n be the Dirac measure at $q(n)$. Each (E, δ_n) is a model of T_{fa} in which δ_n is σ -additive. Suppose for contradiction that a theory T as described exists; then each $(E, \delta_n) \models T$.

Let $\mathcal{U}$ be a nonprincipal ultrafilter on $\mathbb{N}$ extending the cofinite filter. By Łoś's theorem, the ultraproduct $\prod_{\mathcal{U}}(E, \delta_n)$ also models T . The charge induced on the diagonal copy of E is

$$\ell(A) = \lim_{\mathcal{U}} \delta_n(A) = \lim_{\mathcal{U}} \mathbf{1}_{q(n) \in A}.$$

If A is finite, $q(n) \in A$ for only finitely many n , so $\ell(A) = 0$. If A is cofinite, $q(n) \in A$ for cofinitely many n , so $\ell(A) = 1$ since $\mathcal{U}$ extends the cofinite filter. Thus ℓ is the finite-cofinite charge.

The sequence $A_k = \mathbb{Q} \setminus \{q(0), \dots, q(k)\}$ satisfies $A_0 \supseteq A_1 \supseteq \dots$ and $\bigcap_k A_k = \emptyset$, yet $\ell(A_k) = 1$ for all k . So ℓ is not σ -additive and does not extend to a σ -additive measure on $\sigma(E)$. Therefore the ultraproduct does not satisfy T . This contradicts Łoś's theorem applied to the assumption that each $(E, \delta_n) \models T$. $\square$

Remark 2.2. For complete model-theoretic precision: the ultraproduct $\prod_{\mathcal{U}}(E, \delta_n)$ is an $\mathcal{L}_{\text{BA},\mu}$ -structure in its own right; ℓ is the charge induced on the diagonal copy of E inside it. Identifying the ultraproduct with (E, ℓ) is harmless for the contradiction, since the relevant failure of σ -additivity is witnessed on the diagonal copy.

3 Corollary in the language of collective exhaustion

In the companion paper, collective exhaustion (CE) is the exact condition under which a compatible finitely additive family extends to a σ -additive measure on the observable σ -algebra. Proposition ?? therefore implies:

Corollary 3.1 (CE is not first-order in the general language). *In the first-order language $\mathcal{L}_{\text{BA},\mu}$ of Boolean algebras with normalized finitely additive charge, no first-order condition implies the extension property characterized in the companion paper by collective exhaustion.*

The companion paper establishes this at the level of query systems (Proposition 3.9): no first-order structural condition in the query-system language implies CE. Corollary ?? shows the obstruction is not an artifact of the query-system formalism. It already appears in the more primitive setting of Boolean algebras with finitely additive charges, where countable additivity is not first-order axiomatizable.

The failure of CE to be structurally derivable therefore reflects a genuine expressive limitation of finitary first-order description: such descriptions can encode coherence, but not the countable-exhaustion behavior required for probability.

4 The representation question

Proposition ?? shows that *one* purely finitely additive charge arises as an ultraproduct of σ -additive ones — that single witness suffices for the non-axiomatizability conclusion. A stronger question is:

Which purely finitely additive charges arise as ultraproducts or ultralimits of σ -additive probabilities?

This is a representation question, and it is strictly harder than non-axiomatizability. It may be true in some form, or may require allowing approximating nets rather than literal ultraproducts. The Yosida–Hewitt decomposition identifies the purely finitely additive part ℓ_p of any finitely additive charge; whether ℓ_p can always be represented as an ultralimit is not settled here and is left as an open question.